

Presenter: So, to start with, how would you like me to refer to your girlfriend? Should I say "your girlfriend," "your partner," do you have a preference?

Participant: You can call her "partner."

Presenter: Okay, got it.

Participant: That's fine.

Presenter: How long have you been together?

Participant: We've known each other for [1-5] years, but if we have to put a label on it, we've been together for a bit over [1-5] year. [1-5] year and some months.

Presenter: Okay. Now, I'd like you to tell me about your love story. How it developed, how you met, all of that.

Participant: Well, we met through a dating app. It was in [city], and we saw each other for [1-5] weeks, and then I was going to leave for [City]. And she was going to leave for [city]. So, we lost touch a bit at that point. We agreed that we would see each other only for a while in [city], and when we left, we would live our own lives separately. We started messaging each other again in [Date], and eventually, we saw each other again when I returned from [City] and finished my studies near [city], in [city]. That's how it started, and then we started a relationship, which we consider long-distance since we didn't live in the same city. And that's that.

Presenter: And how did you feel that feelings developed between you?

Participant: I think we expressed what we felt. Both of us tried to be honest about our feelings for each other. During my [redacted] period, at one point, we talked again, and she mentioned that she had feelings for me. I admitted that I didn't necessarily have feelings for her at that time. And then, when we saw each other again later, I started having feelings for her. It wasn't easy for me at first. It almost didn't work out between us because when we first started seeing each other again, we began to really express our feelings for each other, and it scared me a bit about the direction it was going and the pressure I put on myself and the commitment it involved. I had a hard time accepting that if I was with someone, I had to adhere to certain...not rules, but expectations of being in a couple. And that's how it started, and I told her at the beginning that it might not work out, which hurt her and me too. But we talked it over, and after some reflection, I accepted things more. And that's how it began.

Presenter: Okay, thank you. Now, if you were to compare the quality of your relationship with that of some of your friends, what would you say?

Participant: I would say that, from my perception, we are a pretty healthy couple. Compared to some of my other friends, for example, regarding jealousy or being open with each other, I consider our relationship to be healthier than some of my friends' relationships.

Presenter: Okay. And now, if you were to compare this relationship with [partner] to your previous relationships, what stands out?

Participant: I haven't had many relationships before her, but I can say that in my previous long-term relationship during high school, there were a lot of unspoken things. I saw the relationship as more traditional, with all the "duties" it entailed, even in terms of love and sex. It was much more closed off, less open.

Presenter: I see. Now, I'd like you to tell me what a high-quality relationship means to you.

Participant: For me, a high-quality relationship is one where you can trust the other person, where you give each other space. Being a couple doesn't mean you have to share everything or

have duties towards each other if you don't feel like seeing each other or talking about something. It's about respect. That's what makes a high-quality relationship in my opinion.

Presenter: So a high-quality relationship is really about trust and respect?

Participant: Yes. And also honesty, of course. These might be common values, but they seem important to me.

Presenter: How can one know they are in a relationship with a lot of trust, honesty, and freedom, in a sense, within the trust?

Participant: Over time, you can see if the other person is trying to hide things or lie. Talking about your feelings helps build trust. Saying when something bothers you and listening to the other person contributes to trust.

Presenter: Conversely, what makes a low-quality relationship?

Participant: Maybe the opposite of everything I just said, but more specifically, if you hide your feelings to protect the other person or avoid conflict, it can lead to frustration. It's also common to see someone taking on a lot of the emotional burden in the relationship.

Presenter: So, it would be a relationship lacking communication?

Participant: Yes.

Presenter: When did you feel your relationship was most based on trust, honesty, and respect? Do you have examples of moments when you felt these feelings strongly?

Participant: I think more at the beginning than now. Due to the story I told you, my partner had to make a big effort of trust towards me when I initially said it wouldn't work, and then later decided to commit. I also had to make an effort of trust in this decision. So, I think it was at the beginning of the relationship.

Presenter: And conversely, did you ever feel it was less present?

Participant: Not less present, but maybe less intense because it's more integrated into our daily lives now.

Presenter: Now, you've mentioned a bit already, but are there other things that are among the most important for you in a romantic relationship, besides trust, honesty, and respect?

Participant: Maybe sharing. Just sharing things, but I'm not sure if that's too common.

Presenter: It's not too common; it's the basis of a couple relationship.

Participant: Yes, yes.

Presenter: Based on your experiences, what is love to you?

Participant: Sorry, my two cats are playing next to me, it's distracting. So, what is love to me? It's a feeling where when you see the person, you want to see them, you feel at ease with them, you enjoy spending time with them. These are things you might find in friendship too, but perhaps more intense.

Presenter: I see.

Participant: More intense because you might care more about the person, or in a different way.

Presenter: I understand, thank you. The cat has arrived!

Participant: Yes, she's on the keyboard now.

Presenter: How important is love in a relationship to you?

Participant: It's essential. Love is the cement of the relationship. If we don't love each other, why spend time together? Why share things? So, it's essential.

Presenter: Now, how do you know that [partner] loves you?

Participant: She tells me, and she shows attention to me. She suggests things when we see each other and listens when I want to talk. Oh, the cat just closed the camera. So yes, that's how I know she loves me.

Presenter: Can you describe one of the last really positive interactions you had with her?

Participant: Well, recently we called each other to book train tickets to visit her parents. Even though it was a simple thing, it was a good moment because we were planning something together.

Presenter: And what about a recent negative interaction with [partner]?

Participant: That's easier to recall. [Redacted].

Presenter: Do you think you should have talked about it immediately rather than waiting?

Participant: Yes, to avoid those unpleasant 30 minutes. But it's not always easy to express feelings right away.

Presenter: I understand. What challenges do you face in your relationship, or have you faced already?

Participant: A small challenge would be changing how we see and interact with each other since our relationship has been long-distance. Now that we're in different cities, we see each other less frequently. Adjusting to seeing each other more often will be a challenge.

Presenter: Can you give more examples of conflicts or disputes with [partner]?

Participant: No, we haven't really had serious disputes.

Presenter: How do you maintain your relationship?

Participant: I don't feel the need to maintain it actively; it happens naturally through little attentions, preparing something special when we see each other, or small gifts and notes.

Presenter: Is there anything that could make you leave [partner]?

Participant: A betrayal, like cheating, especially if she doesn't talk to me about it afterward.

Presenter: Do you think this relationship is good for you?

Participant: Yes, it is. It brings me serenity and joy, even though I believe one can be happy alone. It enriches my life.

Presenter: Can you give concrete examples of how this relationship benefits you?

Participant: There are many things I do with [partner] that I wouldn't do alone, like going to museums, outdoor cinemas, or certain dates.

Presenter: Does she encourage you to go out?

Participant: Yes, though I do go out with friends too. It's just different activities.

Presenter: Do you feel like the same person today as before your relationship?

Participant: I'm roughly the same person as just before our relationship, but not the same as [6-10] months before. My view on relationships has changed, and I've grown.

Presenter: How has this relationship changed you?

Participant: It has shown me that a relationship can bring a lot of positivity without the negative aspects I previously associated with couples.

Presenter: Did you feel that being in a couple meant losing freedom?

Participant: Yes, but it was more about the assumption that there would be both good and bad times in a relationship. With [partner], the negative aspects are minimal, so it feels healthy.

Presenter: Did you think that jealousy was inevitable in a relationship?

Participant: Yes, because my previous relationship was full of jealousy. But with [partner], I've never felt jealous, and she hasn't mentioned feeling it either.

Presenter: Do you think [partner] has changed during your relationship?

Participant: Yes, she seems more confident and open with me now.

Presenter: Would you say this relationship makes you feel secure?

Participant: Yes, it brings stability and allows me to project myself into the future without worry.

Presenter: Do you feel you can tell [partner] anything without fear of judgment?

Participant: Yes, I do.

Presenter: When you confide in her, do you feel comforted?

Participant: Yes, she helps me gain perspective and calm down.

Presenter: Can you give an example of this happening?

Participant: Recently, I adopted cats and felt overwhelmed. Talking to [partner] helped me calm down and see things more clearly.

Presenter: Now, let's talk about the role of sexuality in your relationship. How important is it to you?

Participant: Society shows that it's essential, but for me, it depends on the couple. It should balance both partners' needs.

Presenter: How often do you have sexual relations, approximately?

Participant: About twice a month, since we see each other once a month for a few days.

Presenter: Are you satisfied with your current sex life?

Participant: Yes.

Presenter: Okay, I'll share my screen now to show you some scales. Do you see it?

Participant: Not yet. Oh, now I do.

Presenter: Can you see when I move the pointer?

Participant: Yes.

Presenter: Great. "In general, my partner truly listens to me." From 1 to 9, where would you place it?

Participant: I'd say 7.

Presenter: Why?

Participant: Because [partner] makes an effort to listen, but sometimes gets carried away with her own stories.

Presenter: Is she talkative?

Participant: Yes, but it's not a problem.

Presenter: "My partner is generally attentive to my needs."

Participant: I'd say 8 or 9 because she listens and considers my needs when I express them.

Presenter: Okay. "How satisfied are you with your relationship?" Between "completely unsatisfied" and "completely satisfied"?

Participant: Very satisfied, but not completely because of the long-distance aspect. So, 8.

Presenter: Okay. I'll stop sharing now. I'll send you a link to a questionnaire.